Car(ry)ing Things

Emotional Abilities of Objects

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Abstract

In this text, I reflected on the thinking and making that unfolded over the last two years. By gathering earlier and recent works from my artistic practice in metal, alongside personal stories and selected theoretical and artistic references, I explored the emotional abilities of objects, particularly within the domestic space.

For thousands of years humans have collected, owned and been drawn to material things not only for utility, but for what they hold and convey. Today however, objects are increasingly perceived as consumer goods, and the constant flow of information creates a sense of disconnection and emptiness. This project emerged from a desire to break through this and to highlight what is often overlooked.

I examined how objects hold traces of life, time and human presence within their materiality. The narrow practical definition of function was questioned, emphasizing instead the emotional, symbolic and metaphorical aspects. I reflected on care, how tending to things can be a way of caring for ourselves and others. The text revealed that by being attentive, these other dimensions of objects can be given space to emerge.

Key Words: Evocative, Objects, Things, Traces, Memory, Function, Care, Everyday Life, Metal, Copper

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Prologue: Above the Ladder

It was out of the ordinary for me to make my way up there, to the attic. The days I decided to do so felt almost solemn. I knew that time would dissolve up there, fade into the periphery. I loved being immersed in curiosity and presence. Dad helped me open the hatch in the ceiling of the small entryway and steady the ladder just enough for me to climb.

Every centimeter of the floor was covered. When my parents bought the house almost 24 years ago, everything from the small apartment in the city, my parents' studios, and the summer house in the countryside was packed up and brought here. Much of it ended up directly in the attic. Things that were meant to be dealt with later or saved for the future. As I grew up, the attic continued to fill.

I could spend hours there in the dim light. No one followed my footsteps. I carefully dug through boxes, ran my hand over surfaces, and smelled the scent of dust, cool air and wood. It felt as if the entire room was full of life and stories and I dreamed myself away. I saw glimpses of my parents lives before me. Glimpses of others. Of my grandfather, whom I never met, since he passed away nine years before my birth. I felt all emotions up there such as love, grief, hope, happiness, sadness and excitement. I tried to understand objects I had never seen before, imagining the places they had been and the lives they had touched.

Every time I went up there, I discovered something new. As I got older, I also found traces of myself there. Memories were stirred in the forgotten objects I had sent up myself during countless room cleanings.

Grasping the Words

Writing this thesis has not come easily. Words are not always my language. My way of thinking is rather visual and rooted in making. So much happens in me when I encounter a material. When I let it take shape directly in my hands or through a tool I'm holding. In those moments, thoughts and questions arise.

This thesis began with single words ending up in my notebook while I was in the studio. Words I later tried to formulate further. Writing has a lot to do with working with my hands. Without doing, the words are hard to grasp. Early in the master's I tried to formulate questions for this project, to articulate what it was about, but got stuck there. Intuition plays a huge role in my practice, and I can't explain what I'm doing or why before it takes shape.

My process takes time. At first there are only small fragments of thoughts and forms that I need to spend time with alone, quietly. As the things take shape, my mind becomes clearer, and the constant dialogue of reflection becomes easier to follow. Although I'm a visual and tactile person, the making has sparked a curiosity for words and writing.

I still find theoretical texts overwhelming and navigating in that world have been difficult. I'm meeting this challenge on my own terms, grounding the writing in the same slow, intuitive process that guides my making. With that said, I hope to share a glimpse of the world that emerges in my making.

" The domain of the hand is not that of words. The domain of the hand is the hand. There is so much it knows, the hand. So much it knows that we rarely think about. And when we do think about it, we often can't describe it, either to ourselves or to each other. So, most of the time, there is only one way to find out what the hand knows and can do: to simply let it show." (Jönsson 2002:59; own translation)

Entering the Work

In the beginning of this project, I asked myself if we can have feelings for objects. If they can evoke emotions in us such as empathy and care, but I already knew the answer. For thousands of years humans have collected, owned and been drawn to material things, not only for survival purposes in the form of utility items and tools. Today, however, objects are increasingly viewed as consumer goods rather than as carriers of deeper emotional and personal values. The constant flow of information today leaves us disconnected, numb and empty. It is as if something in us gets lost, or fades, when we enter adulthood.

These reflections resonate with Glenn Adamson's discussion of the decline of what he calls *material intelligence*, an instinctive human capacity to understand and engage with the material world. He notes that we are all born with this faculty, which is why children love their teddy bears, but it has diminished over time as material knowledge has become increasingly specialized and complex. Adamson argues that we risk losing touch not only with objects, but the intelligence and empathy they embody (Adamson 2018:4).

In response to this I want to highlight the poetic, emotional and symbolic value of things, from the sentimental and nostalgic to the historical. As you may have already understood, my answer to the question above is yes, of course objects can evoke emotions in us, we just need to pay attention. I do not have a clear answer on why I am doing this, it feels more like an urge, a need to connect and to break through a sense of absence.

I have gone back and forth on how much of myself I want to reveal and how personal I want to be in this text. At the same time, I have

realized that engaging with these themes is nearly impossible without including some personal stories. Therefore, I use myself as a starting point, and my practice also becomes an investigation into my own relationship to objects.

To understand things and their capacity to hold emotions, I have returned to the objects of childhood and memory. As my hands work, my vision expands. I look for the things, and within them I catch glimpses of intensity. I search for traces and feel longing. Using objects within the domestic space as a starting point, I focus on the inherent qualities and stories they hold and explore how these can be brought into a more public space.

I work primarily in metal, creating objects mainly in copper and bronze, materials I fell in love with during my bachelor's which I completed in 2024. These materials are easy to shape once you know how. They are quite persistent and when the form is set, it sometimes seems as if it is frozen in time. I explore this, but also how they age and collect traces through patination and other marks. I use a range of traditional metal techniques, such as raising, bronze casting (where an original is sculpted in wax or wood), sawing, welding, patination and enamel. The focus lies on what each piece needs.

I want to develop the project into a series of works, both wall-mounted and freestanding. I do not always know what object to make next, sometimes they simply find me. As one of my favorite artists, William Kentridge, has stated, his practice is grounded in a principle of openness to discovery rather than knowing in advance what will be made. His statement, "I was recognising things as they emerged," resonates with my own way of working (cited in Berning

Sawa, 2025). Some of the work I am making reflect things I have owned, seen, met, longed for or dreamt about. The goal is that the works invite you into a room, or world, with shapes and colors you somehow recognize. And where the viewer and the objects meet in an exchange of emotions and stories.

In the coming pages I will connect the themes to my own practice, through examples from both new and earlier works. The works are not presented chronologically, therefore I have added not just the year but also the month they were made. The pieces appear where they best align with the theme discussed to give a better sense of my thoughts. Some works are included even though they will not take part in the final exhibition.

The first section, *Material Witnesses*, examines how things can carry traces, hold memories and reflect us. *Function Beyond Utility* explores definitions of functions beyond the practical and how these can evoke emotions when given space. The final section, *Caring for Things*, addresses the tenderness and care humans, especially older generations, feel toward things.



Image 1
Me casting bronze in sand

Material Witnesses

My grandma Ingmarie passed away in the spring of 2022, and a couple of weeks later my dad came home with things inherited from her. He put all the things he was not keeping on the floor in a room so my two sisters and I could divide the things between us. I didn't know what to do with them, so I put everything, except the golden bracelet she always wore, in a moving box to deal with it later. The box ended up in my basement until January 2025, when I moved to a new apartment. I went through the box, which I hadn't given much thought to over the years and noticed small stickers with her initials on all the metal objects. I remember seeing them in different rooms in her house, on the floor next to the sofa, beside the fire stove, on wooden furniture and hanging on the kitchen wall. I couldn't stop wondering about the initials. Did she put them there to make sure we knew they belonged to her and not the man she spent her last 30 years with? And why did I choose them to inherit?

I feel a tenderness for these objects, patinated by time and with quiet dents that tell stories of life. For some, they may look aged, without value or function. But to me, and perhaps to her, they hold deep emotional meaning. I will never know the full story of the objects, where they came from before, whose hands have held them, where they once stood or whether they were ever being practically used. What I do know is the urge I felt to unpack the box and place the objects where I can see them.

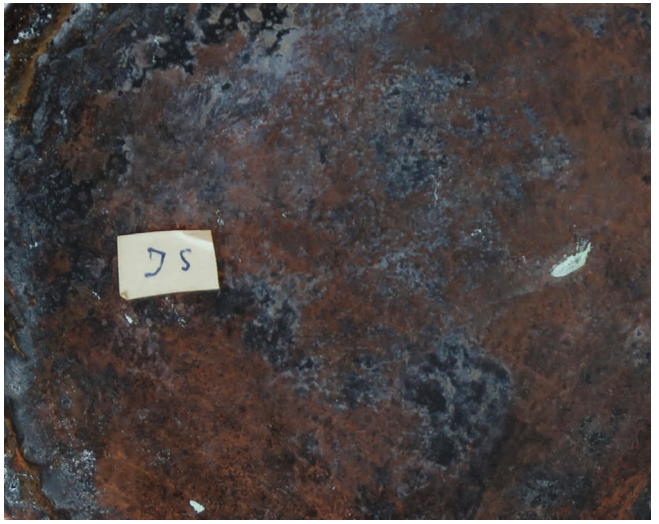


Image 2
The bottom of a saucepan with grandma's initials

"It is a labour in vain to attempt to recapture it: all the efforts of our intellect must prove futile. The past is hidden somewhere outside the realm, beyond the reach of intellect, in some material object (in the sensation which that material object will give us) which we do not suspect. And as for that object, it depends on chance whether we come upon it or not before we ourselves must die." (Proust 2022:53).

Peter Cornell writes about Proust's novel, where things lie waiting for us, and it is through random encounters with them that a bridge between the present and the past is formed (Cornell 1993:13). In this way, objects can serve as a key to a person, a place or a moment in time, awakening memories and sensations that connect the present to what has passed. For example, inherited things can trigger memories and emotions even more strongly than photographs, becoming powerful symbols of the people they belonged to.

Juliet Ash talks about this, saying objects can be classed as a 'prompt' to "our conscious lives of inexplicable mysteries which exist as reminders of people who are absent" (Ash 1996:220). The more objects become imprinted and embellished with age and meaning, the deeper the connection between owner and possession. Similarly, Sherry Turkle believes that objects can serve as emotional and intellectual companions that anchor memory, sustain relationship, and provoke new ideas (Turkle 2007). In her book Evocative Objects, she collects stories in which people reflect on ordinary objects and emotions attached to them. Some especially highlight the role objects play during significant life transitions (Turkle 2007).

In this sense, my grandmother's objects can be understood as evocative, not because what they are, but because they mediate memory, loss and invite reflection. The value of them is not located in usefulness, but in the emotions they hold. The objects act as material witnesses to a life, holding presence rather than explanation.

This understanding of objects as material witnesses also shapes how I relate to objects beyond inheritance, and how I look at the things

I am drawn to. Over the years, I've collected photographs of items I've encountered in museums and other places. These images consist of fragile objects with cracks. Some are bent together or have missing pieces. Each one carries traces of life and time which intrigue me. They don't stand in the cabinets with the same pride as the rest, yet they still get to exist.

There are several reasons why these objects appeal to me. They evoke curiosity and empathy, and I sense a certain depth in them. They carry their own histories. There is a stillness and melancholic presence that invites reflection. The marks they carry show that they have lived, like material witnesses. Although the term appears in other contexts, I use it here to describe and explore these traces and the ways in which objects hold memory and carry images of us.

Another layer of my fascination for these marks comes from my interest in human beings, our inner lives and ways memory shapes who we are. When I was younger, I worked as a caretaker in an elderly care home, an experience that taught me to listen, to notice the small details of daily life and to appreciate the quiet richness of a life lived over decades. Older people carry so much in them, an entire life full of stories. Sometimes stories they don't even remember, only the feeling that remains. When a person is gone, only those who knew them remember them directly. The rest is left to images and objects.

I still remember some of the rooms of the persons living there. Some brought many things, a whole home, some brought the one thing that mattered the most, it could be anything from a blanket to a chair or a painting. I once heard an elderly woman say in a documentary, which one I can no longer remember, that she had

not changed anything in her home because she does not want to lose her memories. This reminds me of a novel I read last year called Memory Police, or in Swedish more beautifully De förlorade minnenas ö (The lost memories island), by Yoko Ogawa from 2022. It takes place on an island where objects gradually disappear and with them the memories tied to those objects vanish as well, showing how closely memories and material things are connected. Those who kept their memories were haunted by the police trying to hide their memories, trapped in a state of longing and grief.

Although this is an extreme case, and we do not lose all our memories simply because an object disappears, there is something truthful in the idea that objects can hold memories. Some memories only arise when we encounter an object, while others remain alive in our minds even after the physical object is gone because of the emotional value it carried. Even when an object is absent, the memories attached to it continue to shape our thoughts and feelings, unless, of course, memory fails us with age.



Image 3
Unknown object at a museum in Berlin

I helped my dad renovate the house facade a while back, and as a thanks he gifted me the old copper downspout. My plan was to use the material for bronze castings. But, when cutting up a piece of it last fall, the inside was exposed, revealing a beautiful patina of stripes in green shades. The downspout must have been in place for 73 years, since the house was built, meaning the patina is a witness of a long past time. Countless days of rain, snow, sun and lives in the house. While I was living in the house, the patina kept forming, and it continued to do so after I moved out.

Seeing the inside, I decided I had to use it for something, it was too beautiful and valuable to throw it into the melting kiln. I had two pieces in front of me. I twisted and turned them, and when I laid them side by side, I saw a shutter, like those found on traditional Swedish tiled stoves. Sometimes, when just being with and touching a material, I see things which I later continue working with.

By turning the downspout inside out, I expose what was once hidden within. The outside, which has somehow witnessed even more of the lives around the house, is instead concealed. The hasp cannot be open, leaving space for speculation about what is behind. It is also a way of searching for time that has passed. When I was a child, my older relatives used to read fairy tales in front of a tiled stove, while I gazed into the fire, watching stories and shapes take form within the flames.

Keeping the shutters closed is, for me, a way of preserving the memories and the feeling of sitting there. Behind the shutters lie countless stories, it is just a matter of imagining. If I open the hatches, the magic risks disappearing. The closed hatches also make me reflect on the child's curious gaze and imagination, which sadly seems to fade for many when entering adulthood. By keeping them closed and revealing the beautiful patina, I hope to awaken curiosity and leave space for imagination.



Image 4
Ridå, copper, Oct 2025

Function Beyond Utility

In this chapter, I explore some different understandings of function, from the practical and symbolic to metaphorical and emotional dimensions, connecting them to historical objects, artists metal-based works and my own practice.

The seemingly broken objects I mentioned earlier remind me of the work *Object that Fell Off the White Cliffs of Dover* by Cornelia Parker, 1992. I encountered this work during the exhibition *Trading Station: How Hot Drinks Shape our Lives* at Manchester Art Gallery, which I visited in September 2023. The work consists of a silver teapot that Parker dropped off the chalk cliff of Dover. The result is a dented object, it bears traces of white chalk, and a piece of the pipe is missing. The exhibition label notes: "The artist enjoys transforming precious objects and heirlooms through destructive processes, rendering them useless or lessening their perceived value."

I believe that what Parker is saying with this work is that function is far broader than just the practical, it can also be emotional, symbolic and personal. This challenges the functionalist perspective on silver and corpus, which was a prominent view in the 1900s, when function was understood as rational and purpose driven (Ljungberg 2023:22). But the idea of function beyond utility is not new. Before the rise of modernism, we see a different, more ritualistic and socially oriented understanding of function (Ljungberg 2023:22). For example, during Sweden's great power era in the 17th and early 18th centuries, certain metal objects, such as the *presenterfat*, a traditional silver plate decorated with repoussé ornaments, were created without a utilitarian function. Instead, their purpose was to impress, to be admired and to convey stories (Tydén-Jordan 2003:80). Parker's work can therefore be seen as part of a longer tradition in which objects hold value and meaning beyond their immediate utility.



Image 5
Parker, Cornelia. (1992). *Object that Fell off the White Cliffs of Dover*

Across time, the view of function has been shaped by cultural and social context. Silver was not unique in this sense, as copper also carried strong social and symbolic significance. Eva Hansson, a Swedish antique dealer, explains in an interview with Sveriges Radio that household copper items were often hung neatly on walls, both as a practical storage solution before cabinets existed and to brighten the kitchens with their reflective surfaces (Sveriges Radio, 2016). However, many of these items were rarely used, instead the well-polished copper served primarily to adorn the home and demonstrate status. Copper was expensive, and many people bought more than they needed to show they could afford it (Sveriges Radio, 2016).

In my work, I am not focusing on status or pride, rather the absence of these aspects that allows other values to become more visible. Copper houseware, once common in long gleaming rows on shelves and walls, as if exhibited, now mostly collects dust at flea markets. Forgotten. Perhaps you, like me, have seen these kinds of objects if not in your parents' home your grandparents or in the homes of other elderly people. I find the material itself fascinating, as it has a clear connection to domesticity, evoking nostalgia not only from its presence in the homes of relatives but also through the marks and the traces in its surface and rich patina, like the ones from my grandmother I reflected on earlier.

In Emelie Liljebäck's master's thesis *Finding Presence of the Absent; To those who are soon forgotten*, she uses copper molds to reflect on working class homes striving to appear middle class, but not quite succeeding. She ties them to women's history and the kitchen as a traditionally feminine space. By assembling secondhand molds, with different patinas, into a large wall piece, she honors the different

women behind them, as a subtle nod to the presenterfat. (Liljebäck 2020:26).



Image 6
Liljebäck, Emelie. (2020). *Finding Presence of the Absent – The Copper Moulds*

My point here is that when we talk about function it is often assumed to mean practical use, but there are so many more layers to it. In the work of Liljebäck, for instance, the molds have never served a utilitarian purpose, instead, they have always been displayed on walls, as an attempt to present a well-polished facade. I see the copper molds as reflections of the different kitchens or rooms they've hung in, and as silent witnesses to the people, especially the women, who lived with them on daily basis.

The objects I create often allude to things from my daily life, memories and surroundings. Through them I aim to highlight the emotional, personal and metaphorical layers of function. When an object is given a different expression, disconnected from utility, it can evoke a sense of care and empathy, as in Parker's work.

These thoughts first emerged in me at the start of my bachelor's project, *Fragile and Impermanence; About Longing for a language*, when I began forming a small vessel and guided by intuition gave it three legs. Shaped first in wax, the vessel carried more weight than its legs could fully support. It stood slightly tilted, struggling to remain upright, as if gravity were constantly pulling it off balance. This vulnerability evoked a sense of empathy and tenderness in me.

This leads me to another aspect of function, the metaphorical. The vessel has historically been used as a metaphor for something human. In the podcast *Material Matters*, Grant Gibson invites the metal artist Adi Toch to talk about her practice. Toch reflects on the vessel as something that accompanies us from birth to death. Serving not only as a container for sustenance and nutrition, but also for feelings and emotions (Material Matters 2024).

I resonate with this way of understanding the vessel, as a container for emotions. The empty space within it invites intriguing speculation. To the viewer, a vessel might appear to be empty, almost like it is waiting for something, but maybe not quite ready. At the same time, it may hold something hidden from others. I eventually made five vessels with legs and saw them as their own beings, but I also saw myself reflected in them. They were made in the light of sadness and melancholy, but there was also a touch of humor, holding both seriousness and ambiguity. Their function lies beyond utility and as reflections of us they embody different emotional states and ways of being. They are graspable for two hands and the tactile reading of the vessels also evoke a sense of caring for ourselves.



Image 7
Untitled Vessels, copper and bronze, Dec 2023



Image 8
Hanging Vessel with Three Legs, copper, May 2025

During the first year of this master's project, I returned repeatedly to the vessel while exploring new ideas, such as shedding and etched images, which I will not discuss here. Another idea that came to me was to create a wall-mounted vessel with three legs, recalling the copper molds once displayed on walls and the forgotten objects now gathering dust at flea markets that I discussed earlier in this chapter. The finished piece, shown in the image to the left, became a hanging vessel. Rather than striving for a well-polished facade or to appear middle class, as the molds Liljebäck refers to, this vessel does not attempt to be anything other than what it is. It does not pretend.

Understanding the vessel and how it can carry deeper emotional meaning, serve as a metaphor for the human and reflect aspects of ourselves played a significant role in my bachelor's work and in the early stages of this project. After making the wall-mounted vessel I have moved on from the vessel as a method of exploration. I remain grateful for its influence. It sharpened my attention to objects and reminded me of objects capacity to be carriers, or containers, as discussed in Material Witnesses. A carrier holds something for us, what we cannot bear ourselves. It carries and cherishes memories. It is strong and faithful. It keeps not only the moments we long to return to, but also the things we might not wish to return to. Fragments of life that shape us, that we want near our hearts, to remember, to hold or to take joy in.

Domestic things carry deep meaning because they are intentionally chosen and kept close, allowing us to shape a personal environment that reflects and builds our identity. Unlike objects in public spaces, those within the home offer a sense of lasting presence and control over the space we inhabit. (Csikszentmihalyi & Rochberg-Halton 1981:17)

The piece Family Portrait refers to the traditional spoon rack used many years ago when people had their own personal spoons. Essentially, it is a shelf that displays individual spoons, often for an entire family, creating a wall-mounted installation. I asked my parents and two sisters to sculpt a spoon each in soft wax. They didn't see each other's work; I wanted them to create intuitively. I made one as well.

Spoons have also long been used as a metaphor for life and something human. The metalsmith Simone ten Hompel reflects on this in an episode of the podcast *Material Matter*s: "We start our life using a spoon, it's the first tool we hold in our hands, so it becomes a metaphor for life itself" (Material Matters 2018). In my piece, each spoon becomes a carrier, holding traces of the person who shaped it, like a portrait. While also serving as a symbol of belonging and the different identities within a family.



Image 9
Family Portrait, bronze and birch, Jan 2025

I later wanted to explore what would happen if I made a single spoon hanging on the wall. The first casting attempts failed, as I experimented with different bronze alloys, resulting in fragmented spoons that can be read as glimpses of lives. There is an absence of something, which makes a feeling of melancholy present. None of the three shown in the images below can be fully seen, not even the one to the right with the shaft still intact. Notice how it faces the wall, not you. Through this, I reflect on how we, as humans, might not show every aspect of ourselves to others in order to preserve a sense of integrity. Hiding one's face can be a way of protecting oneself from the surrounding, for example when in tears. With my work, I do not want to reveal everything but rather leave space for the viewer to interpret and question what they see.



Image 10, 11, 12
Untitled Spoons, bronze, May 2025

I have talked about function as status and power symbols, metaphors, things as carriers for emotions and reflections of us. Another point I want to bring up is our tendency to turn to things in times of distress, loneliness or sadness. I believe that we can find comfort and seek solace in objects, which then function as companions. As children, when we felt alone and sad, who did we turn to if not our things?

In the early weeks of the fall semester in my second year of the master's, I created a work called I hold you. During an exhibition visit, I noticed myself playing with a button in my pocket. The plastic felt smooth between my thumb and forefinger. It had been a long day, and I felt overwhelmed and a little restless. The button spun between my fingers. This made me reflect on how we cope with inner stress, restlessness, nervousness, anxiety and other emotions in everyday life. I thought about the everyday objects we turn to for sensory stimulation, comfort and calm. Things that no longer serve their original function. Like the button in my pocket, it no longer holds the sweater together against the cold, but it holds something together within me.

The work consists of 14 cast bronze objects, representing things that I and others touch for comfort and solace, such as a hair tie, keys, lip balm, lighter and a piece of paper. I exhibited it in a group show with my class at The Cell in October 2025, and the response was beautiful. People connected with the objects, shared their own stories and described other items that held similar meaning to them. These conversations showed me that turning to things is an instinctive need for many of us. The objects have no intrinsic monetary value, their worth lies instead in the memories or relationships that people have formed with them.

Function, as explored in this chapter, goes far beyond utility. Objects are not just tools, they also carry emotions, memories and human presence, acting as companions and reflect who we are. Seen in these broader, more personal terms, everyday objects hold significance beyond their practical use. Function beyond utility is how objects shape us and are shaped by our experiences, through which we find meaning, comfort, and a sense of belonging.



Image 13
I hold you, bronze, Oct 2025

Caring for Things

At my mother's aunt's house, there is a frame hanging on the wall and inside it hangs a flyswatter. She inherited it from her mother, my great-grandmother Karin. It was once broken and repaired by Karin's hands, carrying traces of her tactile tenderness. The flyswatter is a trace of her life and her hands, a proof of her existence. She chose to repair it instead of throwing it away and buying a new one, reminding me of the care and attentiveness we all need to find our way back to. Something earlier generations took for granted. My mother's aunt saw value in the flyswatter. Instead of discarding it, she chose to inherit it. In doing so, she continues Karin's care, and by tending the object, she honors both Karin and the life embedded in it.

The flyswatter resonates with what I am exploring in my work. I had not seen it for some time and felt an urge to revisit it and therefore made my own interpretation of it in copper and steel. It is enameled in red with a matte finish, a glossy surface felt too strong and new. I broke it apart and repaired it, in the same way as the one in the frame. It becomes a symbol to awaken awareness and show that trivial things matter. It is also a way for me to come closer to her.

Repairing things allows objects to live longer in an otherwise disposable society. It shows care and attention, reminding me of kintsugi, the Japanese tradition of repairing broken pottery with lacquer mixed with powdered precious metals, often gold. The technique embodies the Japanese philosophy of wabi-sabi, defined as "an aesthetic or world view characterized by finding beauty in imperfection, impermanence, or simplicity" (Oxford English Dictionary, n.d.). It draws attention to the intentionally highlighted cracks that are usually made by highly skilled professionals. While

this philosophy resonates with what I aim to raise awareness to, I find greater beauty in simple homemade solutions through its human, pure, fragile and genuine character. I feel a stronger empathy for these things, as they quietly celebrate both the story of the object, the persons behind it and the small, intimate moments of everyday life.



Image 14
Karin, copper, enamel, jute twine, steel, Nov 2025

The stories and traces embedded in objects are something I also encounter in Berit Lindfeldt's work, one of Sweden's foremost sculptors. I visited her studio in Gothenburg in November 2025. Entering her atmosphere was deeply touching. Lindfeldt has a remarkable sensitivity to material, an ability to give the most ordinary things meaning and new context. Found things are combined into abstract forms that carry a tangible presence of hand, heart and brain. She sees and observes in a way many seem to lack today. Perhaps this is what Adamson describes as material intelligence.

There is often a sense of sadness, loss and longing in the things she makes, yet I can also see her joy in making them. It feels as if she is giving form to both mental and physical states. The work often revolves around the home, perhaps it has something to do with getting older, searching for who you are and reflecting. Her sculptures function as junctions between past and present, a way of working that resonates with my own. While she is often using found things I make my own interpretations of objects and translate them into a new material. Lindfeldt's retrospective exhibition at Liljevalchs in 2014 was titled *The Edge of Existence*, in Swedish *Tillvarons kant*. Things that may exist in the periphery can be given space if you notice them.

> "How often, in other words, are you in the contact zone? In a way, it's not so hard – just a matter of redirecting your awareness." (Adamson 2018:82)

In Lindfeldt's work, this redirection of awareness becomes material, allowing what is often overlooked to surface and take form.



Image 15
In Berit Lindfeldt's studio

Creating objects that allude to domestic spaces and placing them in a public setting, such as a gallery, also becomes an act of care. When we look after things, we also care for each other and ourselves. Paying attention to them helps us cherish our surroundings, relationships, fragments of time, and objects that are often overlooked. The works in the image to the right were made with these reflections in mind. Although these objects might initially appear randomly chosen, they have more in common than their round shape.

The piece on the left is a lace doily, a traditional textile usually made by hand using various thread techniques, here crafted in copper with white enamel and the same matte finish as the flyswatter. The middle object is a saucer, a small plate typically placed under a coffee or teacup, cast in bronze with an oxide patina. Lastly, to the right is a button, also made in cast bronze.

Much like the copper items mentioned earlier, these objects often end up on shelves, in drawers, tucked into boxes, or stored in cabinets where they are rarely used or noticed. Thrift stores are full of them, and I also encountered them at the homes of older generations and in the boxes my dad brought home from my grandmother after her passing. She had a large collection of buttons in different colors and shapes. They reminded me of the clothes she used to knit for me, my sisters, cousins, and our dolls when we were children. As we grew older, she instead spent her time crocheting granny squares for blankets, while the buttons remained stored away, as if waiting to be used to repair and hold things together.

There are so many of these objects that it becomes almost unclear where they belong. Their practical purpose is no longer obvious, and their original context has been lost. By hanging the work on the

wall, I bring them into a new setting and attempt to tender them, giving them attention.

When objects are taken out of context, as in Lindfeldt's practice or in the works shown here, their emotional abilities becomes more visible. There is an absence in them, perhaps a person, a place or a sense of belonging which gives them a quiet sadness, as if they are longing or waiting for something. I am also reminded of the singular spoon mentioned earlier, which tells a different story than the ones in Family Portrait.

For me, it is not important that the viewer knows my personal stories or connections to each piece. I would rather encourage them to form their own interpretations and spend time with the objects. Through attentive encounters, an exchange of stories, care and emotions can take place.



Image 16
Rebus, copper, enamel, bronze, Feb 2026

Wrapping Up

Humans have long been drawn to material things not only for their utility, but for what they hold and convey. Objects can evoke the wide range of emotions, as I experienced in the attic as a child. Reflecting on the chapters *Material Witnesses*, *Function Beyond Utility* and *Caring for Things*, I see how the emotional abilities of objects intersect. By slowing down and paying attention, these layers are given space to emerge. This sensitivity is a latent faculty within us, inherited from previous generations, that simply requires attentiveness to awaken. The objects I have encountered, from my grandmother's copper items to those I have made during this process, have made this faculty more present in me.

Using myself and objects within the domestic space as a starting point, I focus on the inherent qualities and stories they hold. It is not important that the viewer knows the personal connections, memories or stories they evoke in me. The ones I do share are only a fraction of what these objects carry, and I also perceive other layers that remain unspoken. For instance, when talking about the flyswatter with others, people recognize their own memories in it, entirely separate from mine. The beauty and strength of everyday objects lie in their ability to connect with many people and evoke empathy. Even a seemingly ordinary flyswatter can hold traces of care and human presence. In this sense, the works could be read as a small archive, holding traces of domestic spaces and the stories within.

The objects emerge one by one when I am in the studio, surprising me with their presence. As they take shape, I feel a growing intensity within me. Just as memories do not always match reality, I do not aim to replicate or use readymades, but to create my own

interpretations. The project is still ongoing as I submit this paper, so I do not fully know how and where it will end. Much remains in the studio, and I will continue exploring and making in a similar way to what has been shown here.

With the exhibition, I aim to invite others into a room or world with shapes and colors that feel somehow familiar, evoking both internal and shared dialogues. Wall-mounted, freestanding and hanging works will form an installation. I have not worked in this format before and do not yet know exactly how it will take shape.

For me, making is a language, a way of thinking, feeling, reflecting and investigating ideas. I see this paper as a glimpse into my thoughts and into what is happening in the studio, as well as a way to articulate my process and broaden my perspective and vision. The texts referenced have helped me gain a wider contextual awareness, and I also hope the selection of authors and artists I have presented make my project and context clearer for the reader.

This exploration has not only deepened my understanding of the emotional abilities of objects, it has also become a search, a longing and a liberation for myself to both past and present moments.

As the title reflects, things carry things, and we carry them. They care for us when we care for them.



Image 17
Bronze casting waiting to be revealed

Thanks to my mother Rebecca, my father Thomas, sister Sonja and Sigrid for your constant support.

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Image Reference List

Image 1: Johansson, Simon. (2026). Me casting bronze in sand.

Image 2: Zornat, Vera. (2025). The bottom of a saucepan with grandma's initials.

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Image 4: Zornat, Vera. (2025). Ridå.

Image 5: Zornat, Vera. (2023). Object that Fell of the White Cliffs of Dover, by Cornelia Parker, photographed at Manchester Art Gallery.

Image 6: Liljebäck, Emelie. (2020). Finding Presence of the Absent – The Copper Moulds. Accessed Feb 19, 2026 https://konsthantverkscentrum.se/medlem/emelieliljeback/
Permission to use image given by Emelie Liljebäck

Image 7: Zornat, Vera. (2023). Untitled Vessels.

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Appendix: Reflections

In the period following the completion of the written paper, the examination and the spring exhibition took place, which opened up for new reflections on the work. Overall, I am satisfied with the exam presentation, the installation and the conversations that followed. This text gathers some of the thoughts that have emerged through this experience.

After submitting the paper and before the final examination, I returned to the studio for a focused working period. This resulted in new works in which I further explored scale. By working across different scales, I aimed to create a world of forms that feel familiar yet slightly amiss and not immediately graspable. I tested the installation in parallel with making the works to better understand how they related spatially and visually to one another.

For the examination, my class and I presented a group exhibition in Havet at Konstfack. I built a wall to create a corner, forming a more intimate space and addressing the limited wall availability. As planned, I chose not to use podiums. Instead, the objects were placed directly on the floor, on the wall and suspended from the ceiling. By avoiding additional display structures, I aimed to reduce contextual framing and allow the material presence of the works to be more direct. The installation aligned with my intention and vision.

During the final examination, I had less than ten minutes to present and had to decide what to prioritize. I focused on the main themes, material witnesses, functionality and care, in relation to the physical works and earlier explorations. I also included personal reflections and references connected to certain objects and materials. However,

I found it challenging to balance the personal and the more general.

This became evident to me in the conversations with the opponents Evelina Hedin and Joanna Sandell. The discussion addressed how art is not about offering all answers, but about evoking curiosity and inviting people to think, feel and dream. They noted that this was conveyed effectively, particularly in how the objects became part of the viewers' own narratives. They also pointed to a tension in the work between what is hidden and what is revealed, and how the removal of certain elements activated their imagination. This feedback led me to reconsider the role of my explanation within the installation, and to trust more in the work itself, that the material, objects and titles can carry meaning independently.



Image 18
The installation during the examination

If presenting the work again, I would consider reducing some of the personal references and focusing more on broader research themes. Referring directly to specific memories, such as those connected to my grandmother, risks narrowing the interpretation of the project in ways that do not fully reflect its broader meaning. In this written thesis, however, I develop these personal references in more depth, as they help situate and articulate my way of working and serve as a starting point for my own understanding. In preparation for the spring exhibition, I therefore wrote an exhibition text that focused more on the how and why of my practice in relation to material, color, scale and theme. I included only a brief reference to childhood and memory as a way of approaching the emotional abilities of objects in domestic spaces, without revealing personal narratives. This shift clarified the broader perspective of the project.



Image 19
Ridå, Untitled and Sockerskål

Another theme in the discussion was color. Over the past two years, I have developed a way of working with enamel, creating matte surfaces and emphasizing unexpected qualities rather than striving for perfect, sleek surfaces. Combined with an interest in patina, this has led me to incorporate a wider range of colors. Some works are built up through many layers, while others carry only a few. The palette was described as “subdued hues” by one of the opponents, which resonates with my intention. These colors connect worn and faded surfaces with time, as well as a dreamlike tone associated with memory.

In this context, a further observation from the opponents stayed with me, a reflection on the white cube and how its whiteness creates a dreamlike space for the objects. This relationship between color, surface and spatial context is something I intend to carry forward.

The conversations during the examination were open and supportive, while also constructively challenging. Questions that I could not fully answer at the time have continued to develop my thinking, contributing to a deeper understanding of my practice.

For the spring exhibition, I had requested a corner or multiple walls but was instead placed along a single long wall in Havet. With only one day for installation due to a delay with the temporary wall, there was limited time for testing and a degree of uncertainty about the outcome. However, the final installation still created a sense of intimacy and did not feel flat or overly linear, as works were installed in varying heights and some extended into the room. This revealed that the work is more adaptable than I previously assumed and not dependent on specific special conditions.

Looking ahead, I want to explore the installation in larger spaces, allowing more distance between the works or spreading them across multiple rooms. I am also interested in seeing how the work operates in relation to other artistic practices and how it shifts through different contexts.

Overall, I am very happy with the work I have made. Despite moments of doubt and stress, the process has been highly rewarding. The feedback received has been encouraging, and I leave this master's program with a stronger artistic language and a clearer sense of direction. I remain curious and motivated to continue developing this practice and to explore the possibilities within this project further.

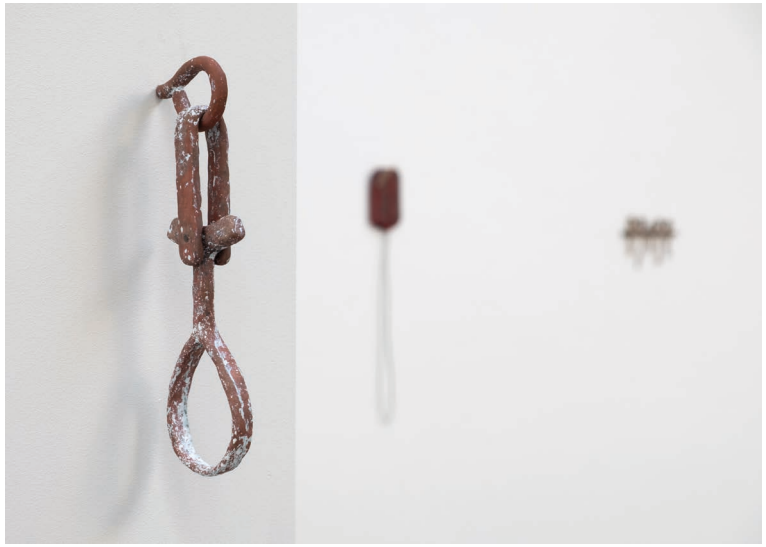


Image 20
Hake, Karin and Family Portrait



Image 21
Rebus, Untitled, Ridå



Image 22
Ridå, Untitled, Karin, Pendel and Family Portrait